The coincidence of the longer-term and structural shift in global economic power with the world financial crisis of 2008–2009 signaled new opportunities for the BRICS. During the crisis, the BRICs governments were quick to voice widespread dissatisfaction with the colossal mismanagement and poor regulation that characterized not only the U.S. subprime mortgage markets, but also Western capitalist institutions considered as global standards, such as Moody's credit ratings and the supposedly neutral London Interbank Offered Rate (LIBOR) benchmark international interest rate.[8] BRICS leaders such as then Chinese Premier Wen Jiaobao accused American policymakers of causing the global financial crisis and warned the United States to "maintain its good credit, . . . honor its promises and . . . guarantee the safety of China's assets." In March 2009, concerned about its massive dollar holdings, the governor of the People's Bank of China (PBOC), Zhou Xiaochuan, expressed his concern over the dollar-centered monetary system and proposed a multicurrency reserve regime based on the Special Drawing Rights (SDRs)—while also taking careful steps toward internationalizing the Chinese currency, the renminbi (RMB). This move was in keeping with what BRICs elites considered the ongoing shift to a multipolar world.[9] According to Wang Jisi, one of China's most prominent academic and policy advisers, since 2008, "the feeling in China [is that] . . . the PRC [People's Republic of China] has ascended to be a first-class global power [while] . . . the United States, despite ongoing great strength, is heading for decline."[10] Meanwhile, "emerging powers like India, Brazil, Russia, and South Africa are increasingly challenging Western dominance and are working more closely with each other and with China in doing so."[11] Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva likewise called for emerging economies to participate in building a "new global financial architecture."[12]

Amid such tumultuous proposals for change, in June 2009, Russia hosted the first BRICs leaders summit. Russian President Dmitri Medvedev insisted, "We should ensure that our states, where billions of people live . . . take part in shaping the new rules of the game."[13] There was a collective sense of global economic power shifting in their direction, dissatisfaction with the lack of serious efforts toward global governance reform, and calls for a more representative world, with power decentralized from the U.S.-